

Text One

Gymshark: How a Young Businessman Built a Sportswear Empire

adapted from an article by Finlay Renwick

In this passage, the writer presents the success story of a young businessman, Ben Francis, from the UK (pictured below).



When he was 14, Ben Francis did work experience at his grandfather's company, which lined industrial furnaces with clay and brick. Staring into a cement mixer, he saw a future he would rather avoid: 12-hour days of hard work and sweat, the promise of a permanently aching back.

'Seeing the sacrifices my grandfather made for his business made me feel comfortable with the concept of financial risk at quite a young age,' says Francis. 'It also taught me that I didn't want to be putting fibre over bricks in a warehouse for the rest of my life.'

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Fifteen years and a £1 billion-plus valuation later, Francis is founder, majority shareholder and chief marketing officer of Birmingham-based Gymshark (a fitness clothing company), one of Britain's fastest-growing businesses. Francis's personal wealth is estimated at £700 million.

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'I think we're building one of the biggest brands in the world here,' he says in the boardroom of the firm's Solihull office, fixing me with an unblinking Silicon Valley¹ gaze. 'By hook or by crook, I want to be one of the biggest and best.'

Gymshark was founded in 2012, when Francis was 19. A self-proclaimed 'very average' student, he discovered an aptitude for IT and the gym at Sixth Form College. The hands-on, problem-solving nature of computers and lifting heavy weights appealed. 'I made four apps and six different websites, all around fitness,' he says. 'The seventh was Gymshark.'

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Gymshark's sprawling campus occupies three buildings in an industrial park, 20 minutes outside Birmingham. There is office space for 400 staff, as well as a vast gym. It's a

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branded theme park in glistening black and chrome. Music blares out of a speaker in reception while multiple screens show videos of Gymshark-sponsored athletes in various states of physical exertion — shark logo always in shot. On my way to the boardroom, I pass messages of affirmation painted on the walls, such as 'Be a Pioneer'.

When we meet, Francis is wearing a charcoal, slim-fit, long-sleeved training top and fitted tracksuit bottoms, both his own brand. At 28, he looks young and healthy, because he is. His hair is freshly faded. I wonder where you get your hair cut when you're worth £700 million. 25

A friend showed Francis how to screenprint T-shirts and his grandmother taught him how to sew. The first designs took two years to get right. Francis paid for the early operations by working as a Pizza Hut delivery driver. 'We were watching fitness videos at that time, so we decided to send some T-shirts, shorts and hoodies to the people in the videos, not because we wanted anything, but because we thought it would be cool if they liked them.' 30

This was 2013, a lifetime ago in internet years, before the word 'influencer' had entered the dictionary; before schoolkids wanted to be live streamers more than they did footballers. The people in the videos liked the clothes and their followers began to ask where they'd got them from. The seeds of a semi-inadvertent viral marketing campaign had been sown. 35

Realising he might be onto something, Francis paid £3,000 for a stall at the Body Power Expo, an annual fitness industry event that takes place in Birmingham each year, where athletes and fans gather to discuss personal-bests, and brands compete for their attention with new products. It turns out the viral marketing had been even more successful than anticipated. 40

'When I left for the expo, we were doing about £300 a day in revenue,' says Francis. 'Afterwards, we went straight to £30,000 a day. I was sat in my mum and dad's living room in disbelief. I said, "Right, here we go," and it's never really stopped since.' This year, Gymshark is on course to sell around 20 million items, averaging 50,000 a day, in 175 countries. In 2020, Gymshark announced it had turned over £260 million in revenue. Nine years down the line and it has, by every available measure, become a giant. 45

While the occasional business degree slogan creeps into his speech — even though he dropped out of Aston University to pursue Gymshark — Francis doesn't appear to embody any of the negative traits sometimes associated with men who have enormous entrepreneurial success at a young age. Resolutely down-to-earth, he is an Aston Villa Football Club season ticket holder and likes Marks and Spencer² ready meals. 50

'I see my mum and dad every weekend,' he says. 'I live 20 minutes down the road from them. I spend time with my girlfriend, I walk my dog. I think I have such a chaotic professional life that I like to keep my personal life as simple and relaxed as possible. My average weekend is gym, walk dog, watch football.' 55

What about the name, I wonder? Where did Gymshark come from? How much market research goes into naming a start-up fitness brand that will one day be worth one billion pounds?

Francis reclines in his chair, behind the table in the room where that deal was signed. 'It was a totally random decision,' he says. 'I bought a £3.50 domain name from a web hosting site. I just thought it sounded quite cool.' 60

*Silicon Valley*¹ – a region of California that is a global centre for technology and innovation

*Marks and Spencer*² – a UK food and clothing store

Text Two

Women in Technology

adapted from an interview with Nicky Saner

In this passage, Nicky Saner, the Chief Executive Officer of a successful technology company, explains why she thinks that there are not enough women interested in careers in technology.



What has been the driving force to get you where you are today?

Since an early age I have always enjoyed setting goals for myself and striving to achieve them, even if this has forced me outside of my comfort zone. I enjoy the reward of seeing people excel and achieve their full potential by breaking down barriers and limiting beliefs that can hold people back — which everyone has. Whether it's an individual or an organisation, it is a great feeling to have a plan in place, empower and support people to achieve their best and to achieve goals. There is nothing more satisfying in business than working in a team to overcome challenges and barriers along the road to success.

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How did you get into the technology sector?

I remember watching *Tomorrow's World*¹ as a child with my family and being fascinated by the various visions of the future and how technology would evolve, but never did I think it would happen this fast, and now, day by day, it is speeding up even further.

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However, I didn't begin my career in technology, and I think it is particularly important today for people to realise that they can change careers. Your experiences in every role will shape you, build your skills and help your career. When I first started working in the technology sector, I didn't have much technical knowledge but the more I started learning, the more I loved it. It is such an exciting industry to be part of, combining innovation, creativity and problem solving. But at the heart of technology and IT are people — all the innovations and services are to make people's daily lives easier, better and safer — and this is why I will remain and continue to enjoy working in this sector.

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Why do you think there are still so few females in the technology sector?

We have a substantial mix of issues that we need to overcome. For me, the top issues are stereotypes, education, confidence and lack of role models.

Firstly, a general stereotype labelling of certain industries as being male or female is something we are all working to overcome (and technology is one of many in this regard). Additionally, I think that there is a misconception of the IT sector and the opportunities within it; there are many diverse fields and areas available to newcomers such as cyber security, robotics and Artificial Intelligence. These are fast-moving and exciting fields to be in for women looking for interesting and challenging careers, but the industry doesn't always do a good job of conveying this. 25 30

There is evidence that one of the reasons the industry is still very male-dominated is education, with the syllabus and course content in many colleges and universities still being very male-orientated — resulting in fewer females completing their studying. I am hopeful that educational institutions will engage with businesses, and it is our duty as leaders of business to be more involved and to help change this. 35

Finally, I think there is an overall lack of confidence from women about getting into the sector and I think some of this stems from a shortage of female role models and female leaders within the industry.

How can we get more women into technology?

I think that there is still an embedded belief that women are not technical, which is from years of ingrained misconceptions, so we need to start by empowering women, building their confidence in the sector and showing them that they do belong here. It is clear that more women are entering and growing within the industry. This should have a fantastic impact as we will start to see a rise in inspiring female leaders and role models that women will look up to, inspiring them to work in the technology sector. Education will play a big role too. With more women presenting at schools, teaching IT courses, and being involved in creating a more diverse and inclusive syllabus, this will build diversity into the system much earlier. 40 45

I also think the change in working habits and increased flexibility will encourage far more women into the sector. We need to look at benefits that might appeal to a broader and more diverse range of employees with as much flexibility as possible — recognising that different benefits will appeal to different people. 50

There will be challenging times, of course, being in a male-dominated environment, but change is well under way and you can be a part of the future of technology. Be confident, find an area that interests you and go after it! 55

*Tomorrow's World*¹ — a British television series, which was broadcast until 2003, about contemporary developments in science and technology